

1.1 Introduction

Education should be free—as in unshackled. Free from classrooms and time tables and syllabi. Any person eager to get educated should have convenient access to the relevant information. Education cannot be free—as in free of charge—since even if the information is freely available, there is a cost incurred in distributing information, either through teachers or through textbooks. But, it can be made dirt cheap or practically free by reducing the cost incurred in its distribution. An opportunity is presented by the Internet to achieve truly, dually free education. The Net offers significantly cheaper storage and distribution channels making it possible to offer information, almost free of charge—since the Net access charges still remain. And the always open nature of the Internet means people can access the information at their convenience—time and place become immaterial.

It is rather unfortunate that a country like India with a large illiterate population has not yet exploited the power of the Web to make education easily accessible. None of the sites reviewed here have an Indian connection. Of course, you could freely download the CBSE textbooks from www.ncert.nic.in/textbooks/index.htm, but merely offering downloads of textbooks would be overlooking the power of the Internet to be a great medium for interactive learning. Additionally, with most of the studying population following state syllabi, this act by NCERT, meagre as it already is, loses even that significance. Nevertheless, it is a step in the right direction, and something all state education boards ought to emulate.

Thanks to the universal nature of science as a field of study, it doesn't matter that the sites reviewed here have no Indian connection. The laws of Newton are the same across the world, as are the equations to calculate different physical entities. So while the presentation and choice of chapters may vary, the content retains its relevance.